

A FREE GUIDE FROM NEXT ERA TRAVEL

The Destination Wedding Blueprint

Planning a wedding in Mexico or the Caribbean, without the overwhelm.

Christine Joy

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

A destination wedding should not feel like a second job.

Most couples start in the same place. Forty open tabs, a group chat with opinions, and a quiet worry that choosing the wrong resort will cost more than money.

I have planned travel for couples and their guests for years, and the pattern is consistent. The weddings that feel easy are not the ones with the biggest budgets. They are the ones where the couple decided what the day should feel like before they looked at a single property.

This guide walks you through that order. First the feeling, then the place, then the guests, then the details. Use it to narrow your choices, ask better questions, and spot the things that quietly make a wedding harder than it needs to be.

> **How to use this guide.** Read it once straight through. Then come back to the questions and checklists and fill them in with your partner. Ten honest minutes with the first page will save you weeks of browsing.

WHAT IS INSIDE

- ✓ Five questions to answer before you choose a resort
- ✓ Mexico or the Caribbean: how to decide
- ✓ Legal or symbolic: what to find out early
- ✓ Your guests: how to make it easy for them to say yes
- ✓ Twelve questions to ask every resort
- ✓ A planning timeline you can follow
- ✓ The mistakes I see most often

STEP ONE

Start with the feeling, not the venue.

Resorts look similar in photos. They feel very different in person. Answer these five questions together, and write down the answers before you search.

1. **How should the day feel?** Barefoot and relaxed, formal and polished, intimate and quiet, or a long celebration with everyone you love. Pick the two words you would most want a guest to use afterward.

2. **Who must be there?** Make two lists: the people the day does not work without, and the people you would love to have. This number shapes everything, including which resorts are even a fit.

3. **How far will your guests really travel?** Think about flight time, connections, and who will need extra help getting there. A beautiful place that is hard to reach can quietly shrink your guest list.

4. **When do you want to marry?** Season affects weather, crowds, and availability. Have a first choice and a flexible second choice.

5. **What do you want to stop worrying about?** Logistics, paperwork, guest questions, vendor coordination. Naming the worry tells you where you most need support.

> **Why this order matters.** When you know the feeling and the guest list first, you can rule out most resorts in minutes. When you start with photos, every option looks possible and the decision never ends.

Space to write: keep your five answers somewhere you can both see them. They are the filter for every choice that follows.

STEP TWO

Mexico or the Caribbean: how to decide.

Both are popular for good reasons, and both can be wonderful. The right choice depends on your guests and the feeling you described on the last page. Use this as a starting point, not a rulebook.

MEXICO

Often a shorter flight from much of the United States, with many direct routes. Wide range of settings, from beach resorts to colonial towns. Many resorts have experienced wedding teams and a lot of venue variety on one property.

THE CARIBBEAN

A large region, so each island has its own character, travel time, and rules. Often chosen for the look of the water, a particular resort brand, or an island with personal meaning to the couple.

THINGS TO COMPARE FOR YOUR OWN SITUATION

- ✓ Flight time and connections for your largest group of guests
- ✓ Hurricane season, which runs through the second half of the year in much of the region, and what the resort's policies are if weather interrupts travel
- ✓ Passport and entry requirements for every guest, checked well ahead of booking
- ✓ Whether you want an all-inclusive setting or more freedom outside the resort
- ✓ How the resort handles weddings: dedicated coordinator, ceremony spaces, rain plans

> **A note from me.** The best destination is the one your people can actually reach and enjoy. A slightly less dramatic setting that nearly everyone can attend usually makes a better wedding than a perfect one that half your list cannot manage.

STEP THREE

Legal or symbolic: find out early.

Some couples marry legally at their destination. Others marry legally at home and hold a symbolic ceremony abroad. Both are common, and neither is better. What matters is knowing which you want before you commit to a place.

- ✓ Marriage requirements differ by country and sometimes by state or island, and they change
- ✓ Ask the resort exactly what paperwork is needed, how far ahead, and who handles it
- ✓ Confirm requirements with official government sources, not only with a venue or a blog
- ✓ If you plan to marry legally at home, ask your local office what they require for your records

STEP FOUR

Your guests: make it easy to say yes.

Your guests are part of the experience, and their trip begins long before the ceremony. A few early decisions make a large difference to how the weekend feels.

- ✓ **Send a save the date early.** People need time to plan travel, time off, and budgets.
- ✓ **Share a clear plan in one place.** Dates, resort, how to book, and who to contact with questions.
- ✓ **Think about group booking.** A coordinated group can make booking simpler and can help keep your guests together.
- ✓ **Plan for the unplanned.** Some guests will need help with flights, rooms, or accessibility. It is easier to know that in advance.
- ✓ **Be honest about the day itself.** Tell guests what is formal, what is optional, and where they are free to explore.

STEP FIVE

Twelve questions to ask every resort.

Ask the same questions of every property so you can compare honestly. Write the answers down and keep them next to your five answers from step one.

- [ ] Is there a dedicated wedding coordinator, and who will I actually work with before and during the event?
- [ ] What is included in the wedding package, and what costs extra?
- [ ] Is there a minimum number of guests or rooms, and what happens if some guests cancel?
- [ ] Which ceremony and reception spaces are available, and what is the weather plan for each?
- [ ] Is the ceremony legally binding, and what paperwork and timing does it require?
- [ ] Can we bring our own photographer, florist, or musicians, and what are the policies for outside vendors?
- [ ] Are there sound, timing, or setup limits for the reception?
- [ ] What room categories are available for guests, and how are they assigned within a group?
- [ ] What group benefits or perks come with booking a block?
- [ ] What is the payment schedule, and what are the change and cancellation terms?
- [ ] What happens if weather or travel disruption affects our date?
- [ ] Can I speak with the team about a site visit, or see recent weddings held in the spaces we are considering?

STEP SIX

A planning timeline you can follow.

Every wedding is different, and shorter timelines are possible. This is a sensible order of operations, with the widest choice of dates and rooms if you begin early.

AS EARLY AS YOU CAN

- ✓ Answer the five questions from step one
- ✓ Draft your guest lists
- ✓ Choose a destination and a short list of resorts

SEVERAL MONTHS BEFORE YOU WANT TO SEND INVITATIONS

- ✓ Confirm your resort, date, and wedding package in writing
- ✓ Understand your legal or symbolic plan and start any paperwork
- ✓ Send your save the dates with a link to one clear information page

IN THE MONTHS BEFORE THE WEDDING

- ✓ Open guest booking and track who has confirmed
- ✓ Book vendors and finalize the ceremony and reception details
- ✓ Plan the welcome gathering and any group activities

IN THE FINAL WEEKS

- ✓ Confirm passports, flights, and arrival times for the whole group
- ✓ Share a simple weekend schedule with every guest
- ✓ Pack your documents and a short list of key contacts

WORTH KNOWING

The mistakes I see most often.

CHOOSING THE RESORT FROM THE PHOTOS

Photos show the best angle on the best day. Ask about layout, how far spaces are from guest rooms, and what the property feels like when it is full.

BOOKING BEFORE CHECKING THE GUEST EXPERIENCE

The wedding is one day. Your guests are there for several. Check room categories, dining, and how easy it is to move around the property.

LEAVING THE PAPERWORK UNTIL LATE

Requirements and timing are easy to underestimate. Ask early, and write down every deadline.

TRYING TO COORDINATE EVERYTHING ALONE

If you are answering the same guest question for the tenth time, you are doing a job someone else could be doing.

SKIPPING THE WEATHER PLAN

Every outdoor event needs a backup. Make sure you have seen it and are happy with it.

FORGETTING THAT YOU ALSO WANT TO ENJOY IT

The best sign of a well planned wedding is that the couple is present for it. Plan for your own ease as seriously as for anyone else's.

YOUR NEXT STEP

If you would rather not plan it alone.

This guide is a good start. Some couples take it from here and plan beautifully on their own. Others want someone to narrow the options, ask the right questions, and handle the coordination, so the wedding feels as good as the photos.

That is the work I do. We begin with a consultation, where I listen to how you want the day to feel and who is coming. Your planning investment is quoted after our conversation, so there are no surprises.

Christine Joy

Next Era Travel
Planning destination weddings and honeymoons

VISIT NEXTERATRAVELCO.COM

This guide is general information to help you plan. Entry, marriage, and travel requirements change, so always confirm current rules with official sources and your resort before you book.